

Danger beneath the surface

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No nation will be as eager to wash away the memories of the previous World Cup as the Netherlands. The night of an almost spectacular comeback in the quarterfinals ended with the orange delegation being driven off the pitch in disgrace by Lionel Messi and Co.

Moreover, the Dutch will enter the latest edition as the best team never to lift the trophy, having reached the finals thrice (1974, 1978 and 2010). Long gone are the days of Johan Cruyff and the Total Football that took the world by storm. At present, head coach Ronald Koeman, in his second stint, is looking to re-establish the nation as a footballing superpower, with a talented and balanced squad at his disposal.

A quiet run to the semifinals of Euro 2024 should serve as encouragement to Koeman, who has largely stuck to the same core. Frenkie de Jong is the most

high-profile inclusion after an injury kept him out of the continental competition. Coming off a double-trophy season with Barcelona, the 29-year-old seems primed to run the show alongside Ryan Gravenberch and Tijjani Reijnders.

However, the Netherlands' biggest strength is its defence, which is anchored by the experienced Virgil van Dijk, Nathan Aké and Denzel Dumfries, although a major miss will be the injured Matthijs de Ligt.

The Dutch, however, do not boast a well-rounded forward line but rather have players capable of delivering match-winning performances, like all-time top scorer Memphis Depay, Cody Gakpo and Wout Weghorst — the architect behind his nation's near comeback against Argentina four years ago.

While the Netherlands seems the clear favourite to top the group, it is



NETHERLANDS

FIFA Ranking: 7

Appearances: 11

Best finish: Runner-up
(1974, 1978, 2010)

Matches: 55

Wins: 30

Draws: 14

Losses: 11

Goals For: 96

Goals Against: 52

Highest scorer in the squad
Memphis Depay (**55 goals**)



JAPAN

FIFA Ranking: 18

Appearances: 7

Best finish: Round of 16
(2002, 2010, 2018, 2022)

Matches: 25

Wins: 7

Draws: 6

Losses: 12

Goals For: 25

Goals Against: 33

Highest scorer in the squad
Ayase Ueda (**16 goals**)

